Around the same time, a film editor from Tel Aviv named Daphne Leef had to vacate her apartment because of major renovations. She found herself priced out of the market, because rental prices had also gone up by more than 40 per cent. In fact, compared to average wages, they were at their highest level since the late 1990s. And buying an apartment was out of the question for many young Israelis: even modest properties in Tel Aviv doubled in value during the 2000s.

Leef decided to pitch a tent in HaBima Square, and invited other Israelis to join her. The national student union quickly joined her protest, along with other youth groups, and by mid-July there were hundreds of tents along Rothschild Boulevard, one of the city's most upscale thoroughfares. Tens of thousands of people took part in a demonstration in Tel Aviv on 23 July, and the protests continued across the country the following week. In a nod to the Arab Spring, the demonstrators chanted "*ha'am doresh tzedek chevrati*", "the people demand social justice". Rallies continued throughout the summer, with the high point on 3 September, billed by organizers as a "million-man march". The actual turnout was closer to 450,000, still a very impressive figure—the largest protest in Israel's history, larger than even the mass rallies after the Sabra and Shatila massacres in 1982.

The rallies grew to include a wide range of movements from across Israeli society: animal rights campaigners, dairy farmers, gay rights activists. All of them joined the "million-man march", and all of them had different demands. Dairy farmers would have been happy with a reasonable price for their products. Hadash, the Communist party, wanted a more fundamental overhaul of the economy. The leaders of the movement came to embrace a fairly radical agenda, with calls for overhauling the tax system, major investments in public housing, and free early education.

"What's scary is that some of the groups are going to get what they want and go home," Doron Ya'akov, a protester, told me in 2011. "People have been talking about how this movement is united. But now it's going to break apart."

Netanyahu, momentarily concerned, named a committee to study Israel's socioeconomic problems and propose a set of solutions. The group was led by Manuel Trajtenberg, one of Israel's top economists. It was due to present its recommendations later in September. Trajtenberg told activists that the government would listen to him, but the committee's recommendations